# Topic 5 — Indian Music

**Covers syllabus (click to expand)**

Indian Music | Hindustani Classical Music | Carnatic Classical Music | Major Gharanas | Musical Instruments | Musicians of India

**Sources:** NCERT An Introduction to Indian Art (Class 11), Natyashastra, Sangeet Ratnakar, UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025 **Last verified:** August 2026

## Current Affairs

- Ustad **Zakir Hussain**, the tabla maestro, died in **December 2024**. He received the Padma Vibhushan in **2023**.
- The **Sangeet Natak Akademi** (संगीत नाटक अकादेमी) was founded in **1952**.
- Vedic chanting entered UNESCO ICH in **2008**.
- Manipuri **Sankirtana** (संकीर्तन) entered UNESCO ICH in **2013**.

## 5.1 Indian Music

Indian art music is built on raga and tala. Two classical branches form after about the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. Folk and film music run parallel.

- **Sangeet** is *gita* (vocal) + *vadya* (instrumental) + *nritya* (dance).
- The earliest musical source in Indian history is the **Samaveda**, comprising liturgical Vedic verses set to melody; it represents sacred chanting rather than modern concert ragas.
- Bharata's *Natyashastra* gives the foundational grammar of *jati* (जाति) melodies.
- Matanga's *Brihaddeshi* (~8th c.) gives the first surviving clear definition of **raga**.
- Sharngadeva's *Sangeet Ratnakar* (**13th c.**) is the great medieval compendium before the north–south split widened.
- The north–south split crystallized during the Delhi Sultanate / Vijayanagara era.
- **Raga** is a melody framework. It is not "a Western scale." It has aroha, avarohana, vadi, samvadi, rasa, and often a time/season.
- **Tala** is a repeating beat-cycle. **Teental** is **16**. Carnatic **Adi tala** is **8**.
- The seven swaras are **Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Dha Ni**.
- Sanskrit names are Shadja, Rishabha, Gandhara, Madhyama, Panchama, Dhaivata and Nishada.
- There are **22 shrutis** in an octave. This is finer than Western semitones.
- The two classical systems are **Hindustani** (north) and **Carnatic** (south). Do not call Carnatic "southern Hindustani."

- Folk and semi-classical music flourish alongside the classical tradition; prominent Uttar Pradesh light-classical forms include **Kajri** and **Thumri**, with **Begum Akhtar** being their most celebrated exponent.
- Sangeet Natak Akademi was founded in **1952**, New Delhi. It is the apex body for music, dance and theatre.

**Treatise ↔ author (UPPCS match set)**

- **Natyashastra** is by Bharata. It treats music + dance + drama together.
- **Brihaddeshi** is by Matanga. It has the first **raga** word.
- **Sangeet Ratnakar** is by Sharngadeva. Later writers call him the ocean of music.
- **Ragamala** (रागमाला) is by **Pundrik Vitthal**. It treats raga–ragini families. He also wrote *Sadragachandrodaya* and *Ragamanjari*.
- **Rasa Kaumudi** is by **Sri Kantha**. It treats music, dance and rasa.
- **Raga Vibodh / Ragavibodha** is by **Somanath** (~**1610**). It has janya–janaka talk. It describes veenas.
- **Chaturdandi Prakashika** (चतुर्दंडी प्रकाशिका) is by **Venkatamakhin / Venkatraman**. It sets out theoretical **melakarta** (मेलकर्ता) for Carnatic.
- **Swaramelakalanidhi** is by Ramamatya (if asked). It is earlier south raga grouping.

> **Logic:** Match the four pairs — **Ragamala–Pundrik, Rasa Kaumudi–Sri Kantha, Raga Vibodh–Somanath, Chaturdandi–Venkatraman**.

**PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2021, Q22**

Match List-I with List-II and select the correct answer using the codes given below the lists.

**List-I (Text)** A. Ragamala B. Rasa Kaumudi C. Raga Vibodh D. Chaturdandi Prakashika

**List-II (Author)** 1. Somanath 2. Venkatraman 3. Pundrik Vitthal 4. Sri Kantha

A. 3 4 1 2 B. 4 2 1 3 C. 2 3 4 1 D. 1 2 3 4

**Show answer**

**Ans: A** — 3 4 1 2.

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## 5.2 Hindustani Classical Music

**North India | raga improvisation | Hindustani**

- The performance arc (instrumental type) is **Alap** (no tala) → **Jor** (pulse) → **Jhala** (fast) → **Gat / Bandish** (in tala).
- **Vadi** is the main note. **Samvadi** is the second main note.
- Time theory is stronger here than in Carnatic. **Bhairav** is dawn. **Yaman** is evening.

- The **10 thatas** of **V.N. Bhatkhande** are the modern Hindustani grouping. They are not the same as **72** melakarta.
- **Vishnu Digambar Paluskar** stands for public concert + notation + Gandharva Mahavidyalaya.
- Gharana is the school system. The oldest khayal gharana is **Gwalior**.

**Vocal forms (one form, one fact)**

- **Dhrupad** is the oldest surviving art form. It is austere. The drum is **Pakhawaj**, not tabla.
- Dhrupad revival names include **Dagar** bani. The Gwalior court of **Man Singh Tomar** is an early dhrupad home.
- **Khayal** (ख्याल) is the dominant concert form today. The drum is **Tabla**. It has bada (slow) + chhota (fast).
- Khayal bloom is **Niyamat Khan Sadarang** and Adarang at **Muhammad Shah Rangeela's** court.
- **Thumri** is light classical. It is romantic *bol banav*. Centres are **Lucknow** (लखनऊ) and **Banaras** (**UP**).
- The primary architect and composer of classical **Tappa** was **Shori Miyan (Ghulam Nabi)** in the 18th-century court of Asaf-ud-Daula; it did not originate under Akbar or Jahangir.
- **Tarana** is attributed to Amir Khusrau. It uses rhythmic mnemonic syllables (*ta na na dere na*).
- The semi-classical **Ghazal** (ग़ज़ल) tradition in Uttar Pradesh was immortalized by **Begum Akhtar** (Akhtari Bai Faizabadi), associated with Faizabad and Lucknow.
- **Qawwali** is Sufi chorus. **Amir Khusrau** is the disciple of **Nizamuddin Auliya**.
- **Dadra** (दादरा) is light, like thumri, often 6-beat.
- **Hori / Kajri / Chaiti** are seasonal light forms. **Kajri** is monsoon of the **Mirzapur–Banaras belt (UP)**.

**PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q38**

The Tappa style of music was refined and developed in the court of which of the following Mughal Emperors?

A. Akbar B. Jahangir C. Shah Jahan D. Muhammad Shah

**Show answer**

**Ans: D — Muhammad Shah.**

## 5.3 Carnatic Classical Music

**South India | kriti | Carnatic bhakti**

- **Kriti** (कृति) parts are pallavi → anupallavi → charanam. The composer *mudra* sits inside the song.
- **72 Melakarta** are parent (sampurna) ragas. Child ragas are **janya**.
- The melakarta theory text is **Chaturdandi Prakashika** by **Venkatamakhin**.
- The concert spine is varnam → kriti (niraval + kalpana swaras) → **Ragam–Tanam–Pallavi** → **tani avartanam**.
- The main tala is **Adi (8)**. Also used are Rupaka and Chapu.
- The main drum is **mridangam**. It is not tabla.

- **Violin** entered Carnatic via **Baluswami Dikshitar** (Muthuswami's brother). It is now a standard accompaniment.

**Trinity (18th–19th c., Thanjavur belt)**

- **Tyagaraja** (**1767–1847**) wrote in **Telugu** on **Rama**. He has the largest output. He is linked to Tiruvaiyaru.
- **Muthuswami Dikshitar** (**1775–1835**) wrote in **Sanskrit** on Devi/Shiva. He has some Hindustani raga colour.
- **Syama Sastri** (**1762–1827**) wrote on Devi (**Kamakshi**). He is known for tala difficulty.
- These are **not** in the Trinity: Tansen, Khusrau and Purandara Dasa.
- **Purandara Dasa** (**16th** c., Vijayanagara) is "Pitamaha of Carnatic music" if the paper asks a founder-teacher before the Trinity.
- **Tyagaraja Aradhana** is at **Thiruvaiyaru**, January. Musicians sing the **Pancharatna** kritis together.

> **Logic:** Tyagaraja **is Telugu Rama.** Dikshitar** is Sanskrit. The Trinity never includes Tansen.

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## 5.4 Major Gharanas

A gharana is a Hindustani stylistic house passed through guru and shishya. It is named for a place or a founder.

- Gharana is a **Hindustani** idea. Carnatic lines run by composer, not gharana.
- **Baaj** is that house's playing/singing feel.

**Vocal (one house, one artist fact)**

- **Gwalior** is the oldest khayal house. It has clear taans. The line is **Haddu–Hassu Khan**. Paluskar taught from this soil.
- **Agra** is **Uttar Pradesh. It has a deep voice. It keeps dhrupad colour inside khayal.
- **Faiyaz Khan** is Agra.
- **Kirana** is Kirana village, **UP** (near Rampur belt). It is slow, tuneful, with microtones.
- **Abdul Karim Khan** is Kirana.
- **Bhimsen Joshi** is Kirana.
- **Gangubai Hangal** is Kirana.
- **Jaipur–Atrauli** has rare ragas and layakari.
- **Kishori Amonkar** is Jaipur–Atrauli.
- **Mallikarjun Mansur** is Jaipur–Atrauli.
- **Patiala** is Punjab. It has open throat and ornaments.
- **Bade Ghulam Ali Khan** is Patiala.
- **Rampur–Sahaswan** is **Uttar Pradesh. It has refined taans.
- **Rashid Khan** is Rampur–Sahaswan.
- **Mewati** is bhajan-coloured khayal.

- **Pandit Jasraj** is Mewati.
- **Bhendi Bazar** is Mumbai. It uses note-stretching. The line is Aman Ali Khan.
- **Delhi** is an older court house. It is a tarana/qawwali neighbour.

**Instrumental**

- **Maihar** is the house of **Allauddin Khan** (Maihar, **MP**).
- **Ali Akbar Khan** is a Maihar sarod/sitar disciple.
- **Ravi Shankar** is a Maihar sarod/sitar disciple.
- **Annapurna Devi** is a Maihar sarod/sitar disciple.
- **Imdadkhani / Etawah** is sitar.
- **Vilayat Khan** is Imdadkhani.
- **Senia** is the **Tansen** line. It has a multi-instrument claim.
- **Punjab** is a tabla *baaj* name if the paper matches drums.
- **Farukhabad** is a tabla *baaj* name if the paper matches drums.
- **Ajrada** is a tabla *baaj* name if the paper matches drums.
- **Lucknow** is a tabla *baaj* name if the paper matches drums.

> **Logic:** Kirana **is** Bhimsen Joshi. Patiala **is** Bade Ghulam Ali Khan. Maihar **is** Allauddin Khan**. Gharana is not raga.

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## 5.5 Musical Instruments

Bharata's four instrument families are **tata** (string), **avanaddha** (membrane), **ghana** (solid), and **sushira** (wind).

Later set splits string into **Tata** as plucked and **Vitat** as bowed.

**Instrument Families (Natya Shastra Classification)**

- **Tata / Tat (Plucked Strings):** Examples include sitar, sarod, Saraswati veena, and tanpura.
- **Vitat (Bowed Strings):** Examples include sarangi, esraj, and violin.
- **Sushira / Sushir (Wind):** Examples include bansuri, shehnai, nadaswaram, and shankh.
- **Avanaddha (Percussion / Membranes):** Examples include tabla, pakhawaj, mridangam, and dholak.
- **Ghana (Idiophones / Solid):** Solid instruments without membranes; examples include manjira, kartal, and the clay pot **Ghatam** (classified as Ghana, not Avanaddha).

**Master Instrumentalists & Characteristics**

- **Sitar:** A plucked string instrument (Tata) with movable frets and a gourd resonator, popularized globally by **Pt. Ravi Shankar** and **Ustad Vilayat Khan**.
- **Sarod:** A fretless plucked string instrument with a polished steel fingerboard, masterfully played by **Ustad Amjad Ali Khan** and **Ustad Ali Akbar Khan**.

- **Saraswati Veena:** The primary plucked lute of Carnatic classical music, associated with Goddess Saraswati.
- **Rudra Veena:** The ancient, deep-toned plucked string instrument of Hindustani music, traditionally used in Dhrupad performance.
- **Tanpura:** A plucked drone instrument that provides the foundational harmonic pitch for classical vocal and instrumental recitals.
- **Sarangi:** A bowed string instrument (Vitat) whose rich, resonant timbre is considered closest to the human voice; traditionally used as vocal accompaniment in Khayal and Thumri.
- **Bansuri:** A transverse bamboo flute (Sushira) intimately linked with Krishna iconography and elevated to classical prominence by **Pt. Hariprasad Chaurasia**.
- **Shehnai:** A double-reed wind instrument elevated to the classical concert stage by **Ustad Bismillah Khan** of Varanasi.
- **Nadaswaram:** A long, powerful double-reed temple wind instrument of South India, central to auspicious Carnatic ceremonies.
- **Tabla:** A paired hand-drum set (Avanaddha: Dayan and Bayan) central to Hindustani Khayal, Thumri, and instrumental recitals; epitomized by **Ustad Alla Rakha** and **Ustad Zakir Hussain**.
- **Pakhawaj:** An ancient barrel-shaped two-headed drum, traditionally used to accompany Dhrupad singing.
- **Mridangam:** The primary rhythmic percussion instrument of Carnatic classical concerts, masterfully performed by legends like **Palghat Mani Iyer**.
- **Kanjira:** A South Indian circular frame drum with monitor-lizard skin, used in Carnatic percussion ensembles.
- **Harmonium:** A free-reed keyboard instrument widely used for accompanying Khayal, Ghazal, and devotional singing.

> **Logic:** Sitar is Tata. Sarangi is Vitat. Shehnai is Sushira. Tabla is Avanaddha. Ghatam is not tabla family.

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## 5.6 Musicians of India

### Medieval / foundation

- **Amir Khusrau** is qawwali and tarana tradition. He is the disciple of **Nizamuddin Auliya**.
- **Swami Haridas** is Vrindavan. Tradition makes him **Tansen's** teacher. He is Braj / UP.
- **Tansen** (Ramtanu) is **dhrupad**. He is Akbar's **Navaratna**. He is Senia line, Gwalior soil.
- Before Akbar, Tansen's patron is **Raja Ramchandra Singh of Bhata / Rewa**.
- The title **Miyan** is linked to Akbar's court. Do not say Akbar *invented* Tansen's art.
- **Baiju Bawra** is a legendary dhrupad rival. He is semi-historical.

### Hindustani vocal

- **Abdul Karim Khan** is the Kirana founder-figure.

- **Bhimsen Joshi** is Kirana. He received Bharat Ratna **2008**.
- **Gangubai Hangal** is Kirana. She is Karnataka, not UP birth.
- **Bade Ghulam Ali Khan** is Patiala. He sang khayal + thumri.
- **Kishori Amonkar** is Jaipur–Atrauli.
- **Pandit Jasraj** is Mewati.
- **Faiyaz Khan** is Agra.
- **Begum Akhtar** is ghazal / thumri. She is **Faizabad–Lucknow (UP)**.
- **Girija Devi** is Banaras thumri. She is **Uttar Pradesh.

### Instrumental

- **Allauddin Khan:** Founder of the Maihar Gharana; legendary guru of sarod and sitar.
- **Pt. Ravi Shankar:** Renowned sitar maestro of the Maihar Gharana; awarded the **Bharat Ratna in 1999**.
- **Ali Akbar Khan:** Eminent sarod maestro of the Maihar Gharana.
- **Vilayat Khan:** Celebrated sitar maestro of the Imdadkhani Gharana.
- **Amjad Ali Khan:** Preeminent sarod maestro of the Gwalior/Senia Bangash lineage.
- **Ustad Bismillah Khan:** The peerless maestro of the **shehnai**, based in **Varanasi** (वाराणसी); he performed at the Red Fort on Independence Day in 1947 and was awarded the **Bharat Ratna in 2001**.
- **Hariprasad Chaurasia:** Eminent bansuri virtuoso.
- **Alla Rakha:** Celebrated tabla maestro of the Punjab Gharana.
- **Zakir Hussain:** Internationally renowned tabla virtuoso; died on **15 Dec 2024**; honored with the Padma Vibhushan in **2023**.

### Carnatic Vocalists & Instrumentalists

- **Purandara Dasa:** Revered as the *Pitamaha* (grandfather) of Carnatic music; codified foundational pedagogical exercises and composed Kannada *devaranamas*.
- **Tyagaraja:** Composed Telugu *kritis* dedicated to Lord Rama; foremost member of the Carnatic Trinity.
- **Muthuswami Dikshitar:** Composed profound Sanskrit *kritis* with intricate raga structures.
- **Syama Sastri:** Composed intense Devi *kritis* in complex talas.
- **M.S. Subbulakshmi:** Legendary Carnatic vocalist who was the first musician conferred the **Bharat Ratna (1998)**; gave a historic performance at the UN General Assembly in 1966.
- **Semmangudi Srinivasa Iyer** is Carnatic vocal.
- **Lalgudi Jayaraman** is violin.
- **Palghat Mani Iyer** is mridangam.
- **Balamuralikrishna** is vocal + composer.

### Festivals (name–place)

- **Tansen Samaroh** is at **Gwalior**, December. It is a tomb festival. It is **MP**, not UP.
- **Tyagaraja Aradhana** is at Thiruvaiyaru, January.

- **Sawai Gandharva** is at Pune. It is the Paluskar–Bhimsen line.

> **Logic:** Tansen before Akbar served **Raja Ramchandra of Bhata. Bismillah Khan** is shehnai + Banaras. MS Subbulakshmi is Carnatic, not Hindustani.

**PYQ — UPPCS Prelims 2019, Q89**

Who among the following kings had given patronage to Tansen before Akbar?

A. Raja Ramchandra Singh of Bhata B. Rajbahadur of Malwa C. Uday Singh of Mewar D. Muzaffar Shah of Gujarat

**Show answer**

**Ans: A — Raja Ramchandra Singh of Bhata** (Rewa).

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